Breaking and Entering

By Sherman Alexie

(Pg 5-17) When I was first learning how to construct a scene, my professor said to me, "You don't have to show people using a door to walk into a room. If people are already in the room, the audience will understand that they didn't just materialize. The audience understands that a door has been used – the eyes and mind will make the connection – so you can just skip the door.

"Skip the door" is a good piece of advice that I've applied to my entire life. Omit all unnecessary information. So in telling you this story, in constructing its scenes, I will attempt to omit all unnecessary information. But oddly enough, in order to skip the door, I am forced to begin with a door: the front door to my home in Seattle, Washington. Once year ago there was a knock on that door.

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INTRODUCTION

Life is made up of an infinite amount of choices. Some inconsequential; others life-changing. In fact, Graham Brown once said, "Life is about choices. Some we regret, some we are proud of. Some that will haunt us forever."

Choices are not always black or white . . . or are they? In Breaking and Entering, Sherman Alexie explores how choices are impacted by ethnic identity, power, privilege and race.

I work at home, but I did not rise from my chair to answer. Bang, bang, bang, bang! It had to be a Jehovah's Witness or a Mormon . . . or a magazine sales kid. Trust me, nobody interesting or vital has ever knocked on a front door at three in the afternoon. So I ignored the knocking and kept at my work. And, sure enough, my potential guest stopped the noise and went away.

But then, a few moments later, I heard a window shatter in my basement – shards of glass dropping onto a hardwood floor. And then one hears – feels – the epic thump of two feet landing on that same floor. Somebody – the same person who had knocked on my

front door to ascertain if anybody was home, had just broken and entered my life.

Looking back, I suppose I should have just run away. I could have . . . the front door into the street, the back door onto the patio, the side door into the alley, or even the door into the garage . . . and made my escape.

But here's the salt of the thing: I believe I was making my way toward the front door – after all the front door was the only place where I could be positive that my intruder was not waiting. But in order to get to the front door, I had to walk past the basement door. And as I walked past the basement door, I spotted the baseball bat. It belonged to my ten-year-old son. A Little League bat, so it was comically small.

Yes, I am a father. And a husband. That is information you need to now. My wife had taken our son to visit her mother and father. So, to be truthful, I was in no sense being forced to defend my family. And I'd never been the kind of man to defend his property. In fact, I'd often laughed at news footage of silly men

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armed with garden hoses as they tried to defend their homes from wildfires. I always figured those men would die, go to hell, and spend the rest of eternity having squirt-gun fights with demons.

So with all that information in mind, why did I grab my son's baseball bat and open the basement door? Why? Trust me, I've spent many long nights asking myself those questions. There are no easy answers. There are many who believe I was fully within my rights to head down those stairs and confront my intruder. There are laws that define – that frankly encourage – the art of self-defense.

In the end, I think I wasn't defending anything at all. Did I walk down those stairs because I was curious? Because a question has been asked (Who owned the feet that landed on my basement floor?) and I wanted to discover the answer?

So, slowly I made my way down the stairs and through the dark hallway into our family room and saw a teenaged burglar. I stood still and silent. Standing with his back to me, obsessed with the task – the crime – at

hand, he hadn't yet realized that I was in the room with him.

Let me get something straight. Up until that point I hadn't made ay guesses as to the identity of my intruder. I mean, yes, I live in a black neighborhood – and I'm not black. There had been news of local burglaries by black teenagers, but I swear none of that entered my mind. I didn't think, there's a black teenager stealing from me. I only remember being afraid.

"Get out of here!" I screamed. "You ******!"

The black kid was so startled that he staggered and nearly fell before he caught his balance and ran for the broken window. I could have – would have – let him make his escape, but he stopped and turned back toward me. Why did he do that? He was young and scared and made an irrational decision. He searched for a door. The door behind me. He paused, weighed his options, and sprinted toward me. I could have made the decision step aside. But I didn't. As that kid ran toward me, I swung the bat at the black teenager's head. When it

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made full contact with the kid's temple, he dropped to the floor and did not move.

He was dead. I had killed him. I fell to my knees, dropped my head onto his chest and wept.

I don't remember much about the next few hours, but I called 911, and led the police to the body.

"Did he have a gun or knife?"

"I don't know. No. Well, I didn't see one. He ran at me. He was going to run me over."

"And that's when you hit him with the bat?"

"It's my son's bat. It's so small. I can't believe it's strong enough to – is he really dead?"

His name was Elder Briggs, a sixteen-year-old kid, backup point guard for the basketball team at Garfield High School. A good kid. No criminal record. So why had this good kid broken into my house? Why?

The investigation was quick but thorough. I was not charged with any crime. It was self-defense. But then nothing is ever clear, is it? I was legally innocent, but was I morally innocent? Shortly after the police

exonerated me, Elder's family organized a protest. I watched the live coverage of the event:

ELDER'S MOTHER: "The police don't care about my son because he's black. Just another black boy killed by a white man. And none of these white men care."

As she continued to rant about my whiteness – all of them, protesters, reporters – were unaware of one crucial piece of information: I am not a white man.

When I heard Althea Riggs misidentify my race – I picked up my cell phone and dialed the news station. [They] put me on live, and my voice played over images of Althea Riggs weeping and wailing at God:

GEORGE: I am watching the coverage of the protest, and I insist on a correction. I am not a white man. I am a member of the Spokane Tribe of Indians.

How could I have been such an idiot? How could I have been so goddamn callous and self-centered . . . I was pissed, mostly at myself for failing to walk away from a dangerous situation. But I was also pissed at Althea and Elder Briggs. Yes, the kid was a decent athlete; yes, the kid was a decent person. BUT . . . he had broken into my house.

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And his mother instead of explaining why her good and decent son had broken and entered a stranger's house, committing a felony, had instead decided to blame me and accuse me of being yet another white man who was always looking to maim another black kid – had already maimed generations of black kids – when in fact I was a reservation Indian who had been plenty maimed myself by generations of white men.

So, Althea, do you want to get into a pain contest? Do you want to participate in the Genocidal Olympics? Whose tragic history has more breadth and depth?

And oh, my God, it was a Little League baseball bat! It weighed less than three pounds. I could have hit one hundred men in the head and not done anything more than given them a headache. But on that one day, I took a swing – a stupid, one-handed, unlucky cut – and killed a kid, a son, a young man who was making a bad decision

but who maybe had brains and heart and soul enough to stop making bad decisions.

Oh, Jesus, I murdered somebody's potential. It was self-defense, but it was still murder. I confess: I am a killer. ***(Long pause)***

How does one survive these revelations? One just lives. Or rather, one just finally walks out of his basement and realizes that the story is over. It's old news. There are new villains and heroes -- criminals and victims to be defined, examined and tossed aside by the media. Life is infinitesimal and incremental and inconsequential. Elder Briggs and I were suddenly and equally unimportant.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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